

Why Resumes Get Rejected — and What Gets Them Accepted

A research report for Sachin Kumar's iOS/macOS job search

Compiled from 2026 recruiter surveys, ATS scan studies,
eye-tracking research, and 26 real iOS job descriptions

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Scope. This is the second research pass, focused specifically on the *reject versus accept* decision. Every claim is sourced. Where a finding **contradicts** earlier advice given in `01_ATS_PLAYBOOK.md`, it is called out explicitly — two findings did.

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1. The numbers on rejection

1.1 The dominant cause is not formatting

Finding	Number
Rejections caused by experience not matching the posting	73%
Recruiters rejecting for impersonal / untailored applications	84%
Recruiters rejecting for lack of customization specifically	54%
Rejected resumes with <50% of the posting's required keywords, <i>even when the candidate had the matching experience</i>	82%
Resumes scoring below the 75-point “qualified” threshold	71.4%
Rejected resumes with a critical format failure	34%
Silent-rejection rate in software engineering	53.3%

Read row four again.

82% of rejected resumes were missing more than half of the posting's keywords *despite the candidate actually having that experience*. That is a **translation failure**, not a qualification failure — and it is precisely the failure mode of the original resume: real unit-testing and REST-API work existed, but neither appeared as a bullet.

1.2 Volume is the silent killer

- A typical posting draws **250 applications**; engineering roles report **2,000+ in the first week**.
- Roughly **5 interviews result per 180 applicants**.
- **53.3%** of software-engineering applicants are *silently* rejected — no response at all.

You are not being rejected. You are being out-ranked and never reached.

Different problem, different fix.

1.3 The Google VP's three red flags

Brian Ong, VP of Recruiting at Google (Forbes, April 2026):

1. **“Always needing to be right” / closed-mindedness.** On a resume this reads as stagnant progression and *no certifications within the last three years* — a signal that you stopped growing.

This applies to you directly.

Both of your certifications are from **2022** — **four years old**. To a Google-style reviewer that reads as “stopped learning in 2022.” Fix in Section 4.

2. **Inability to handle ambiguity.** *“The ability to thrive in ambiguity is probably the most critical lens.”* Red flag: no examples of pivoting, adapting, or operating without enough resources or information.

You *have* this — the legacy-library migration, the MVVM to VIPER refactor, and building a diagnostics tool nobody asked for. It was simply never framed that way.

3. **Waiting for leadership instead of being the leader.** “*Deferring to hierarchy all the time.*” On the page this shows up as passive verbs: “supported,” “assisted,” “contributed to,” “worked on,” “helped with.”

Your original resume opened a bullet with “Contributed to architectural refactoring...”

That is the exact passive construction named here.

1.4 Other documented rejection triggers

- **Unprofessional email** — 76% of such resumes ignored. *You are fine.*
- **Photo, date of birth, marital status, father’s name** — legacy Indian biodata fields. They break parsing, add zero value, create bias risk, and some international ATS platforms **flag resumes containing photos as non-compliant.** *You have none of these. Keep it that way.*
- **No side projects** — 82% of resumes have none. *You have three, one live on the App Store. A genuine top-18% advantage that was buried.*
- **Job hopping / no tenure** — *You are fine: one employer, continuous, with a promotion.*

2. What actually gets a YES

2.1 The 7.4-second scan, measured

The Ladders eye-tracking study put recruiters in front of real resumes with an eye tracker. Average initial screen: **7.4 seconds** (up from 6.0 in 2012). The measured gaze path:

1. **Current job title and company** — *most fixation time of any element*
2. Previous title and company
3. Right side: employment **dates**, checking for steady progression
4. Down to **education**
5. Then, only if it survived, actual bullet content

Winning resumes had simple layouts, clear headings, bold titles, bulleted achievements and generous white space. Losing resumes had clutter, no white space, **multiple columns** and long sentences.

Implication.

Your job title is the single most-looked-at element on the page — and the original resume rendered it in *italic small text on the second line* of the entry. Every variant now places a bold title headline directly under your name.

2.2 The top third decides everything

- Recruiters spend **80% of their attention on the top third** of the page.
- Resumes with **measurable results in the top third** are **40% more likely to be short-listed.**

Implication.

A summary that is merely a list of framework names wastes the most valuable real estate you own. Numbers belong above the fold — which is why several new variants open with a **Key Achievements** block: three quantified lines before the work history begins.

2.3 Tailoring, measured three separate ways

Measure	Untailored	Tailored
Interview rate	2.07%	4.23%
Callbacks	1×	3×
Hiring managers who actively prioritise evidence of tailoring	—	55%

2.4 Referrals dwarf everything else in this report

Path	Hire rate
Job-board application	7%
Referral	30%

Referrals are **7% of applications** but **30–50% of all hires**. Referred candidates are approximately **15×** more likely to be hired.

This is larger than every resume optimisation in this folder combined.

Eleven resumes cannot beat one warm introduction. Use the resumes to *convert* referrals, not to replace them.

3. Two corrections to earlier advice

3.1 Correction 1 — Two pages now beat one page

The **OnePage** variant was built on the older “one page under 8 years” convention. The 2026 data reverses this:

Finding	Number
Recruiters who now prefer two-page resumes	68.6%
Recruiters who still prefer one page	21.6%
HR professionals saying 1–2 pages is ideal ($n = 1,013$)	82.1%, with 51% preferring two
Relative preference for two-page over one-page	2.3×
Two-page resumes rated higher on “comprehensive summary of the candidate”	+21%
Time recruiters spend reading a two-page resume	more than 2× longer

Mid-career (3+ years) is explicitly called out as needing two pages, and **98.8% of recruiters value clean formatting** — they would rather you use a second page than cram page one.

What changes.

Sachin_Resume_OnePage.tex is now a *situational* tool: referrals, career fairs, postings that explicitly say “1 page,” and US early-career applications. **It is not your default.** Your default is a two-page variant.

3.2 Correction 2 — Certification recency is a scored signal

The 2022 Coding Ninjas certificates were previously treated as neutral filler. Per Google’s VP of Recruiting, *no recent certifications within three years* is read as evidence that a candidate stopped growing. Yours are four years old. This is a real, fixable negative.

4. Your specific action list

Ranked by impact per hour spent.

1. **Get referrals.** 30% versus 7% hire rate. For every target company, find one 42Gears alum or second-degree LinkedIn connection. This outweighs everything else here.
2. **Kill every passive verb.** Google’s VP names “supported” and “assisted” as an instant red flag; your original said *“Contributed to architectural refactoring.”*
3. **Earn one recent credential — this year.** Cheapest honest options, in order:
 - Ship the **Swift 6 strict-concurrency migration on CodeForge** and write a short public post about it. This simultaneously closes your #2 skills gap, proves recent learning, and demonstrates thriving in ambiguity. Best single move on this list.
 - An Apple Developer / Swift certification, or a reputable Swift Concurrency course with a dated certificate.
 - A conference talk, blog series, or open-source contribution dated 2026 — demonstrated growth counts, not only formal certificates.
4. **Put numbers in the top third.** Use the **Key Achievements** variants.
5. **Make your job title impossible to miss.** Most-fixated element in the eye-tracking study.
6. **Frame the ambiguity stories.** You have three. Do not just list them — say what was unclear and what you decided.
7. **Apply within 72 hours of posting.** With 2,000 applications in week one, queue position is a real variable.
8. **Never send the same PDF twice.** 84% of recruiters reject impersonal applications.

5. India-specific findings

5.1 Naukri and Indian portals

- Naukri runs **its own parser and search ranking** before any company ATS sees you. Tables, columns, text boxes and graphics scramble it.
- Use **exact phrases** recruiters type: **SwiftUI** not “Swift UI”; **Objective-C** not “Obj C”; **CI/CD** not “continuous integration”.
- Profile order that ranks: headline → current role → key skills → summary → resume upload.
- Razorpay, Swiggy and Zomato now receive thousands of applications per role through Naukri-integrated AI screening.

5.2 Service companies versus product companies

- **IT services** (TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Cognizant, Capgemini, Accenture, LTIMindtree) hire on a bench-to-project model. They want **each project listed with stack, your role, team size, and client industry**. A senior Big-4-IT HR quote: *“I can reject 80% of resumes in 30 seconds because they’re missing one of three things: 10th–12th marks, project details, or backlog status.”* Infosys uses **iRecruit + SmartRecruiters**; Wipro uses **Phenom People**.
- **Product companies** want impact, scale, ownership and metrics — the format you already have.

5.3 Applying abroad from India

- Add **one line of context** for names a foreign recruiter will not recognise. Recruiters abroad do not know 42Gears or CGC Landran.
- **US:** achievement-focused, 1–2 pages, ATS-critical.
- **Europe:** called a “CV”, two pages standard, profile summary expected, academics weighted more heavily.
- State **work authorisation and timezone** explicitly for remote roles — it is a knockout question, and knockout questions are what genuinely auto-reject.

6. The honest bottom line

You asked for a resume that no recruiter can ignore. Here is what the data actually supports:

- A great resume moves you from roughly **2%** to **4–5%** response on cold applications.
- A **referral** moves you to **30%**.
- Nothing moves you to 100%. With 2,000 applicants per role and a 53.3% silent-rejection rate in software engineering, some strong candidates are never opened. That is arithmetic, not a flaw in your resume.

What this resume system *does* guarantee: when a human or an LLM does open yours, there is no reason to put it down. No parsing failure, no unevidenced claim, no passive verb, no buried metric, no missing title. That is the entire controllable surface. Everything beyond it is referrals, timing and volume.

7. Sources

Rejection data

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- Resume.io — 58 resume statistics 2026
- JobSprout — 10 resume mistakes that get you rejected
- HiroCV — 50+ resume statistics for 2026
- Enhancv — AI hiring statistics 2026
- Metaintro — Why qualified applicants still get rejected

Recruiter behaviour

- Ladders eye-tracking study (PDF)
- HR Dive — recruiters look at resumes for 7 seconds
- Forbes — Google exec on 3 resume red flags
- Brainmanager — 20 resume green flags
- SEEK — green flags to look for in candidates

Resume length

- Resume Optimizer Pro — ideal resume length
- Gainrep — one page or two, the 2026 recruiter verdict
- Resume Worded — can a resume be two pages

Referrals

- Zippia — 25 employee referral statistics
- ERIN — enterprise referral statistics 2026
- The Interview Guys — referred candidates get hired 4x more often

Big tech and startup

- Tech Interview Handbook — FAANG-ready resumes
- MirrorCV — FAANG SWE resume guide 2026
- Interview Kickstart — SWE resume for FAANG
- Recruiting From Scratch — what startups screen for
- SWE Resume — startup resume guide

India

- CVefy — ATS resume format for Naukri India
- CVForge — resume format for TCS, Infosys, Wipro and Capgemini
- CV Prime — 15 ATS resume mistakes India 2026
- ResumeVera — Naukri profile optimization 2026
- Rezumea — Indian resume format guide 2026
- CVCompose — personal information on a resume 2026

International

- Resume Optimizer Pro — international resume guide
- VisualCV — CV formats for 30+ countries
- Infinite Resume — Indian resume for international jobs